

Seafood Paella (Variation 14)

Tags: seafood, spanish, rice, dinner, gluten-free | Prep: 30 min | Cook: 45 min | Serves: 3

Ingredients

- 200 g paella rice (Bomba or Calasparra)
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 0.5 large onion, finely diced
- 0.5 red bell pepper, diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp smoked paprika
- 0.5 tsp sweet paprika
- 0.5/4 tsp saffron threads, dissolved in 2 tbsp warm water
- 200 g canned crushed tomatoes
- 0.6 litres seafood or chicken stock, warm
- 150 g large prawns, shell on
- 150 g mussels, scrubbed and debearded
- 100 g squid rings
- 100 g firm white fish, cut into chunks
- 0.5 cup frozen peas
- Salt and black pepper
- fresh basil and lemon wedges to serve

Method

1. Heat oil in a large (40 cm) paella pan or wide shallow skillet over medium-high heat.
2. Cook onion and pepper for 8 minutes until soft. Add garlic and both paprikas; cook 1 minute.
3. Add crushed tomatoes and cook for 5 minutes until thick.
4. Add rice and stir for 2 minutes to coat in the tomato sauce.
5. Pour in warm stock and saffron water. Stir well and spread rice evenly. Season.
6. Bring to a boil, then reduce to a steady simmer. Do not stir from this point on.
7. After 10 minutes, nestle in fish chunks and squid. After another 5 minutes, add prawns and mussels.
8. Cook for 8–10 more minutes until all seafood is cooked and mussels have opened.
9. Scatter peas over the top and remove from heat. Let rest uncovered for 5 minutes.
10. You should see and hear a slight sizzle as the socarrat (crispy rice crust) forms at the bottom.
11. Serve directly from the pan with lemon wedges and parsley.

Chef Tips

- The socarrat — the golden crispy layer at the bottom — is the prized part; listen for a gentle crackling.
- Never stir paella after adding the stock. Movement prevents the socarrat from forming.
- Saffron is non-negotiable for authentic flavour and colour — bloom it in warm water first.